

SUBIR HALDER



Medicine Woman

Not too many know this but Mamata Banerjee keeps her bag stuffed with medicines of all sorts for any emergency. "I don't carry these only for myself," says the Trinamool Congress chief, adding she is "very good" at bandage dressing and had learnt this during her sundry trips to the nursing homes after opposition attacks. *by Abhijit Dasgupta*

The Brahmin MANIFESTO

Politics is the art of possibilities and a steamed up Railway Minister Lalu Prasad emitting encomiums for Brahmins could be a case in point. The RJD boss recently asked his son Tej Pratap to touch the feet of Brahmin Mahasabha members who called on him to commit support to the RJD. This is a turnaround for the iconoclast who once mocked at the ritualistic traditions that Brahmins propound. Many feel Lalu is aiming at bête noire Nitish Kumar, whose party has not fielded any Brahmin in Bihar. He is doing everything to wean away Brahmin votes from the NDA. *by Amitabh Srivastava*



SYMBOLIC Dissonance

Imagine a politician with a briefcase on election eve, or one with a carrot. No wonder a good number of candidates in Bihar have shown extreme reluctance for these "politically incorrect" election symbols that include walking sticks and whistles too. Many believe the connotation would always be negative, no matter who gets a briefcase or carrot. In fact, the Election Commission has bracketed as many as 59 symbols as free, which means these are readily available and can be allotted to independents or candidates of

77.6 per cent candidates did not get enough votes to save even their deposits in 2004 General Elections.

HARD FIGHT

God help Ananth Kumar! As of now, a professor (JD-S), Air Deccan founder (Independent) and a scholar from the US (Congress) are among those the four-time BJP MP from Bangalore South may have to do battle with.

Rice RUSH

Rice politics enters Orissa. While Naveen Patnaik used it to influence the poor at Rs 2 per kg, the BJP and Congress now promise it at Re 1 if come to power.



B K RAMESH

Star Rising

Kannada actor Tara, who won the National Award three years ago for her role in *Hasina*, is the latest star on the BJP's horizon. "The women-centric programmes is what drew me to the party." Just like she rose from a junior artiste to a star, she hopes to work from the "grassroots to whatever responsibilities" that come her way.

by Stephen David



MADHUMANGAL SINGH

unregistered parties. A number of candidates are said to be extra cagey when it comes to selecting a symbol. For instance, a ceiling fan, table lamp or an electric pole as a symbol may end up infuriating the electorate in Bihar and Jharkhand, which are infamous for power-cuts during summer months. Similarly, a harmonium or violin may dovetail nicely with voters from a constituency known for extending cultural patronage. But perhaps not in Bihar where Bahubalis may find these symbols a little effeminate and instead opt for macho ones like a road-roller. *by Amitabh Srivastava*